81% of AEP's Data Center Backlog

Just Evaporated. My Bot Found It First.

By Luke Jafarieh — Grid Realization Pipeline

In short: A public regulatory filing revealed that 24,300 MW of data center demand behind AEP's Ohio grid quietly withdrew after a new tariff forced developers to put money down. The queue went from 30,000 MW to 5,700 MW overnight. Wall Street still hasn't connected the dots.

Three weeks ago, a filing hit the Ohio public utility commission docket. Nobody was reading it.

My pipeline was.

It flagged the document at 2:47 AM. By morning I had read it twice.

The Finding

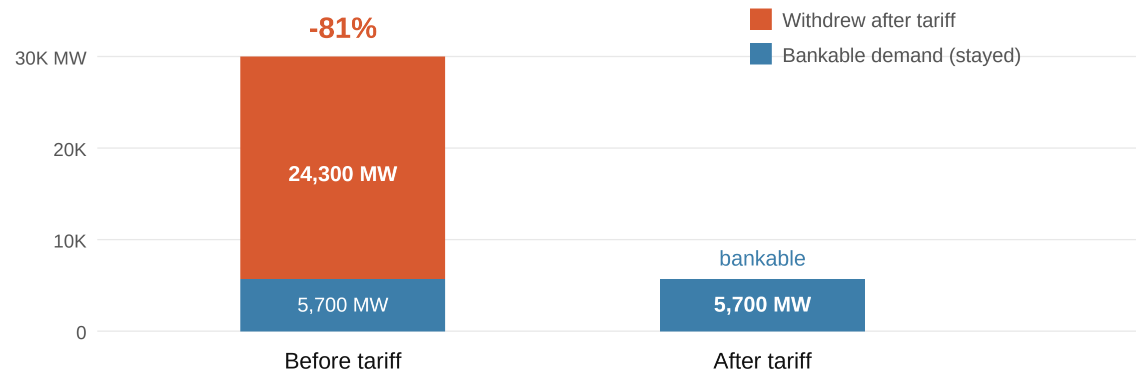
Here is the exact language from the filing, verbatim:

> *"The Columbus data center interconnection cluster has withdrawn 24,300 MW of uncommitted capacity requests following implementation of the take-or-pay tariff. Expected commercial operation dates have been extended by an average of 14 months across the affected queue positions. AEP projects that confirmed contracted load has declined from 30,000 MW to 5,700 MW of bankable demand."*

-- American Electric Power, Ohio PUC System Impact Study Update

AEP had 30,000 megawatts of data centers in line to connect to its Ohio grid. When regulators forced those developers to financially commit -- pay a deposit or give up their spot -- **81% of them walked.** The 30,000 MW of demand AEP has been telling investors about? The real number is 5,700 MW.

30,000 MW	5,700 MW	-81%
Queue before tariff	Bankable demand after	Withdrew overnight



AEP Ohio -- Columbus data center interconnection queue before and after take-or-pay tariff.

Why This Gets More Dangerous From Here

This is not an AEP-specific problem. The tariff that triggered Ohio's collapse is spreading across the entire PJM grid -- 13 states, 65 million people, the electricity backbone of the Mid-Atlantic and Midwest.

The policy timeline:

Ohio (done): AEP implements take-or-pay. 81% of the Columbus queue withdraws.

Maryland (enacted 2025-2026): Two laws passed forcing BGE, Pepco, and Delmarva (all Exelon, $EXC) to create take-or-pay tariffs for loads over 25 MW. Maryland's ratepayer advocate is in federal court over $1.6 billion in grid upgrades built for data centers that may not show up.

New Jersey (passed June 30, 2026): 85% commitment required, 10-year term, projects over 50 MW. Pending Governor Sherrill. PSE&G ($PEG) and JCP&L ($FE) exposed.

All 13 PJM governors: Joint Statement of Principles, January 2026. Data centers pay for their own grid upgrades. Full stop.

COLLAPSED
Ohio
$AEP

ENACTED
Maryland
$EXC

PASSED LEGISLATURE
New Jersey
$PEG / $FE

NOT YET
Pennsylvania
$PPL

NOT YET
Virginia
$D

NOT YET
IL/IN/MI/WV + more
PJM others

All 13 PJM governors signed a joint Statement of Principles, Jan 2026: data centers pay for their own grid upgrades.

PJM interconnection -- take-or-pay tariff status across 13 member states.

The Specific Stocks to Watch

Utility	Ticker	Signal
American Electric Power (Ohio)	$AEP	Negative. Queue collapsed 81%. Watch Q3 guidance.
Exelon BGE/Pepco/Delmarva (Maryland)	$EXC	Caution. Tariff enacted. Queue data not yet public.
PSEG / PSE&G; (New Jersey)	$PEG	Watch. Tariff standards set within 12 months of signature.
FirstEnergy / JCP&L; (New Jersey)	$FE	Watch. Same NJ exposure as PEG.
PPL Electric (Pennsylvania)	$PPL	Positive for now. 9 GW pipeline, no tariff yet.

The Information Gap Is the Point

The filing was publicly available the morning it was submitted. It sat in a government portal, in a docket, behind search filters most people don't know how to navigate.

Step	What happens	Who knows
1	Filing hits Ohio PUC docket	GRP flags it at 2:47 AM
2	Regulatory analysts read it	Days to weeks later
3	Sell-side picks it up	Weeks later, if at all
4	Management addresses it	Next earnings call
5	Consensus estimates revise	Months after the filing

Grid data is informationally rich and operationally inaccessible. That gap is the edge.

What I Built (and How It Found This)

GRP is a Python ETL pipeline I built from scratch. It hits regulatory APIs on a schedule, extracts PDFs, scans for keywords, and runs Z-score anomaly detection on live EIA demand data. The Ohio filing matched five signal keywords: *take-or-pay, queue withdrawal, bankable demand, commercial operation date, cost allocation.*

I'm a student. I taught myself Python building this, using Claude as a coding partner. No formal CS background -- just a thesis and enough stubbornness to see it through.

Four standalone scripts: github.com/ljafarieh/grp-public

The core loop:

```
demand  = pull_hourly_demand(ba_code="AEP", days_back=30)
spikes  = detect_anomalies(demand)          # 2.0σ over 168-hr window
docs    = get_new_documents(participant="American Electric Power")
for doc in docs:
    result = scan_pdf_url(doc["pdf_url"])
    if result.has_signal:                   # 5+ keywords → flag
        alert(doc, result)
```

What I'm Watching Next

Maryland BGE/Pepco dockets -- tariff is enacted. When does the queue move?

New Jersey BPU -- once Sherrill signs, tariff standards set within 12 months. First filings from PSE&G and JCP&L will be the tell.

AEP Q3 2026 earnings -- does management revise data center load guidance? That's when this filing becomes a market event for retail investors.

Pennsylvania -- PPL has 9 GW of pipeline. No take-or-pay yet. Ohio's 30,000 MW looked real too.

The grid is the biggest infrastructure story of the decade. It plays out in documents nobody reads. I'm trying to change that.
